

The Process of Listening

Listening is not a process of transferring an idea from the mind of a speaker to the mind of a listener. Rather it is a process of speaker and listener working together to achieve a common understanding. The listening process is a circular one. The responses of Person A serve as the stimuli for Person B, whose responses in turn serve as the stimuli for Person A, and so on.

i. Receiving:

Listening begins with receiving messages the speaker sends. Here you receive both the verbal and the nonverbal messages. You should maintain your role as listener and avoid interrupting the speaker until he or she is finished.

ii. Understanding:

The understanding must take into consideration both the thoughts that are expressed as well as the emotional tone that accompanies these thoughts. For improved understanding, you should see the speaker's messages from the speaker's point of view; avoid judging the message until you have fully understood it – as the speaker intended it.

iii. Remembering:

Messages that you receive and understand need to be retained for at least some period of time. You should identify the central ideas in a message and the major support advanced for them.

iv. Evaluating:

Evaluating consists of judging the messages in some way. Often this evaluation process goes on without much conscious thought. You should identify any biases, self-interests, or prejudices that may lead the speaker to slant unfairly what is presented.

v. Responding:

Responding occurs in two phases: (1) responses you make while the speaker is talking and (2) responses you make after the speaker has stopped talking. In responding try to be supportive of the speaker throughout the speaker's talk by using and varying back channeling cues (I see, yes, uh-huh) and express support for the speaker in your final responses.

Why is listening so important in life and at work?

Listening is a key component of effective [communication skills](#).

Regardless of the type, listening is key to understanding what other people are really trying to say. Without listening, it's easy to get something wrong and make assumptions.

On the other hand, when you actively listen, you can fully communicate with someone else.

Listening is the most important part of communication. That's because it allows you to come up with a substantial and meaningful response. You can pick up on subtleties you wouldn't have otherwise, [especially with body language](#).

If something isn't clear, you can ask clarifying questions. This is something you might not have done without active listening.

At work, communication is an important soft skill. According to LinkedIn's 2019 Global Talent Trends report, 80% of companies say that soft skills are increasingly important to their success.

Listening is also important for [productive collaboration](#).

According to the same LinkedIn report, collaboration is the third most important soft skill companies need.

Imagine trying to collaborate if you can't actively listen to your colleagues. Information gets lost, and misunderstandings occur.

The same can happen if everyone on the team uses different levels of listening. Some people will be more engaged than others. Not everyone will get the same understanding of the same conversation.

You can avoid this if everyone actively listens to each other.

Plus, when you actively listen, your colleagues and your superiors will notice that you come up with meaningful responses.

Listening is also crucial if you want to learn effectively.

Without attentive listening, it can be easy to miss small details that make a difference in your learning.

You can improve team communication with active listening games.

In one such game, you and your colleagues can split up into groups of two. The first person in each group is given a picture, while the other person is given a pen and paper.

The second participant needs to ask questions in order to accurately draw the image the first participant is holding.

Finally, you can practice active listening by having all participants listen to one person speak for three to five minutes. During this time, no other participants may speak.

Afterwards, the other participants need to paraphrase what they think the other person said.

Types of Listening

The principles you follow in listening effectively should vary from one situation to another. There are several types of listening you can develop both at home and at work. Let's explore the types of listening, why they matter, and what they can look like:

1. Participatory and Passive Listening:

As a listener, participate in the communication interaction as an equal partner with the speaker, as one who is emotionally and intellectually ready to engage in the mutual sharing of meaning.

Passive listening allows the speaker to develop his or her thoughts and ideas in the presence of another person who accepts but does not evaluate, who supports but does not intrude. By listening passively you provide a receptive and supportive environment.

2. Empathic and Objective Listening

If you want to understand what a person means and what a person is feeling, you need to listen with some degree of empathy. Empathic listening is a means for both increasing understanding and for relationship enhancement.

There are times when you need to go beyond empathic listening to measure the meanings and feelings against some objective reality. You should strive especially to be objective when listening to friends or foes. Your attitudes may lead you to distort messages – to block out positive messages about a foe and negative messages about a friend.

Empathetic listening is useful to help you see from other people's perspectives.

Using this type of listening, you can try to understand someone else's point of view as they're speaking. You can also try to imagine yourself in the other person's shoes.

Instead of just focusing on their message, you can use empathetic listening to relate to someone else's experiences as if they were your own.

This is different from sympathetic listening.

With sympathetic listening, you try to understand someone's feelings to provide support. But you don't necessarily try to imagine what it'd feel like to be in their position.

Here's an example:

Let's say your superior just announced that this week's company outing is canceled due to budget cuts.

By using empathetic listening, you can tell how much pressure your superior is feeling. You can imagine yourself having to break the bad news.

You know there's pressure from higher-ups to respect the budget. You also know that there's pressure from employees.

Instead of getting upset, you understand why your superior made this decision. That's because you can imagine what it's like to be in their shoes at this moment.

Objective Listening: Objective listening is to go beyond empathy and measure meaning and feelings against some objective reality. It is completely focused on the person who is speaking with no thoughts or notions about how any of the information relates personally to them. For example, you acknowledge a person's work and efforts regarding a project accomplishment despite having serious personal conflicts with him.

3. Nonjudgmental listening

Effective listening includes both non-judgmental and critical responses. You need to listen non-judgmentally, with an open mind with a view toward understanding. You should first listen for understanding and suspend judgment. You need to listen fairly, despite an out-of-place expression or a hostile remark.

If meaningful communication is to take place, you need to supplement open-minded listening with critical listening.

4. Critical Listening/ Analytical Listening

Listening with a critical mind will help you analyze and evaluate the messages. It is a process for understanding what is said and evaluating, judging, and forming an opinion on what you hear. The listener assesses the strengths and weaknesses of the content, agrees or disagrees with the information and analyzes and synthesizes material.

5. Internal Listening: Here as the listener your focus is on yourself and your own thoughts rather than the speaker. As the speaker is talking about his/her own incident that they encountered, the listener is engulfed in his/her own thoughts and begins questioning or perceiving the similar situation with themselves. The listeners' own thoughts enter into the conversation. For example, 'Did I turn off the oven at home?' or 'what should I do after work? Should I visit my grandmother?'

6. Surface and Depth Listening

Surface: In most messages there is an obvious meaning that we can derive from a literal reading of the words and sentences that is surface level reading. For example, you are reading a text and looking at the grammatical structure, the subject-verb agreement.

Depth: But there is often another level of meaning that could be in depth. For example, when you read a text, you start looking at the metaphors used in it and relate them back to the text in order find out the implicit/ underlying meaning provided. Most messages function on two or three levels at the same time.

Do not disregard the literal meaning of interpersonal messages in trying to uncover the more hidden meanings. Balance your listening between surface and the underlying meanings.

7. Informational/ Content listening

When you want to learn something, you'll use informational listening to understand and retain information.

It usually takes a high level of concentration to perform this type of listening. That's because you need to be highly engaged to understand a new concept.

You also need to apply critical thinking to what you are learning. This is so you can understand what you're learning within the context of relevant information.

Some examples of informational listening include:

Work training

Self-paced learning at home or at work listening to an educational ebook

When you know how to use informational listening, you empower yourself to become a better learner. By actively learning and improving yourself, you can become a more valuable asset in your place of work.

You can also feel more fulfilled when you pursue your passions and learn something new at home.

8. Discriminative listening

Discriminative listening is the first listening type that you're born with. Everyone innately has discriminative listening skills.

You use this type of listening before you even know how to understand words. Instead of relying on words, discriminative listening uses tone of voice, verbal cues, and other changes in sound.

Discriminative listening is how babies understand the intention of a phrase before they can understand words. If someone speaks to them in a happy and amused tone of voice, they'll smile and laugh back.

They can also tell who is talking because they recognize different voices. But discriminative listening isn't just for babies.

If you're listening to a conversation happening in a foreign language, you'll likely automatically use your discriminative listening skills.

These will allow you to analyze tone and inflection to get an idea of what is going on.

You can also use nonverbal cues to listen and analyze. For instance, someone's facial expressions, body language, and other mannerisms can tell you a lot about the meaning of someone's message.

You shouldn't discount discriminative listening, even if you understand someone's language.

This listening style is key to understanding the subtle cues in a conversation. Using this listening skill can help you read between the lines and hear what remains unspoken.

Here's an example:

Let's say you ask one of your colleagues if they agree with a course of action.

They say yes, but you can tell from their body language, such as shifting uncomfortably, that something is wrong.

Using your discriminative listening skills, you can pick up on this and ask them if they're certain. You can also ask if something is going on that they'd like to discuss.

9. Biased/ Selective listening

Biased listening is also known as selective listening.

Someone who uses biased listening will only listen for information that they specifically want to hear.

This listening process can lead to a distortion of facts. That's because the person listening isn't fully in tune with what the speaker wishes to communicate.

Here's an example:

Let's say your superior is briefing you on a new project. You're waiting to hear about the details of this assignment because you've been excited for a long time about it.

Because you're so focused on the details of the assignment, you don't fully hear everything your superior says. As a result, you hear your superior explain how you'll be judged on this project, but you don't fully process it.

Because you don't have this information, you may not perform as well as you could if you had understood all the details.

10. Sympathetic listening

Sympathetic listening is driven by emotion.

Instead of focusing on the message spoken through words, the listener focuses on the feelings and emotions of the speaker.

This is done to process these feelings and emotions.

By using sympathetic listening, you can provide the support the speaker needs. You can understand how they're really feeling, not what they say they are feeling.

The speaker will feel heard and validated when you take the time to pay attention in this way.

Sympathetic listening is crucial if you want to build a deeper relationship with someone in your life.

For example, let's say you run into a work colleague at the grocery store. They seem upset, so you decide to listen to what they have to say.

You also use sympathetic listening to feel how they are feeling. In doing this, you notice how frustrated they are about the lack of recognition they are getting at work.

As a result, you can offer your support and sympathize with their situation.

11. Comprehensive listening

Unlike discriminative listening, comprehensive listening requires language skills. This type of listening is usually developed in early childhood.

People use comprehensive listening to understand what someone is saying using words.

Several other types of listening build on comprehensive listening. For example, you need to use comprehensive listening to use informational listening and learn something new.

At work and in your life, you'll likely use a combination of comprehensive and discriminative

listening to understand the messages people are giving you.

For example, let's say your colleague briefs you on a project. You'll need to use comprehensive listening to analyze the words and understand the message.

You'll also use comprehensive listening when you receive feedback.

12. Critical listening

If you need to analyze complex information, you'll need to use critical listening.

Using critical thinking while listening goes deeper than comprehensive listening. Instead of taking the information at face value, you can use critical listening to evaluate what's being said. Critical listening is crucial when problem-solving at work.

For example, you'd use this type of listening when trying to choose how to handle an unusual and complex client request.

You need to use this skill to analyze solutions offered by other people and decide if you agree or not.

To do this, you don't just need to hear their words. You also need to look at the bigger picture and compare everything you know.

13. Reflective Listening

It is about using Reflections to show you are listening. Reflection is one way for you to show you are actively listening to speaker. You can do this by repeating back what the speaker has said or by labeling, paraphrasing, and summing up how you think he feels. Restate and clarify what the speaker has said; don't ask questions or say what you feel, believe or want.

14. Appreciative Listening

Appreciative listening is a type of listening behavior where the listener seeks certain information which they will appreciate, and meet his/her needs and goals. One uses appreciative listening when listening to music, poetry or the stirring words of a speech. Sometimes, appreciative listening means we are listening for pleasure. Examples include when we are tuning our attention in to a song we like, a poetry reading, actors in a play, or sitcom antics on television.

15. Pseudo Listening

Pseudo-listening is a type of **non-listening** that consists of appearing attentive in conversation while actually ignoring or only partially listening to the other speaker. An example of pseudo-listening is trying to multitask by talking to someone while watching television or completing work. Pseudo-listening is the most ineffective way to communicate because after the conversation one will not have retained much of the information that was said.

Learn all types of listening to improve your life and your work

One type of listening isn't better than the other. Instead, these seven types of listening work together to help you better understand the messages you receive.

By being a good listener, you can become a better communicator, avoid misunderstandings, and learn new information more easily.

Eight Types of Listening Responses

1. Silent Listening: Providing positive nonverbal responses without verbal feedback. Allow students to vent and “get it all out.” Sometimes students simply need to be heard without the threat of being interrupted and judged
2. Questioning: Occurs when the listener asks the speaker for additional information. Some questions are sincere, that is, aimed at understanding others, whereas counterfeit questions are disguised attempts to send a message rather than receive one. As educators, sincere questions can let students know that you are interested in what they have to say. It can also be a method for allowing students to come up with solutions on their own, as it is a great way to lead them to the answer instead of providing one for them.... Empowerment!
3. Paraphrasing: providing feedback that restates the message the speaker sent. This is an effective way to reduce confusion and ensure that an educator understands the student’s perspective and point of view. It can include: • <i>Putting the speaker’s words into your own</i> • <i>Offering an example</i> • <i>Reflecting the underlying theme</i>
4. Emphasizing: A response style used to show that the listener is identifying with the speaker. Empathy involves perspective taking, emotional contagion, and having a genuine concern for the student. It can include brief statements such as: <i>“I see,” “Wow!,” “My goodness.”</i> It can also include statements such as: <i>“I can imagine how tough that would be to handle.”</i> <i>“It is really no fun to feel unappreciated.”</i> <i>“This really means a lot to you, doesn’t it?”</i>
5. Supporting: A type of response that reveals the listener’s solidarity with the speaker and reflects the listener’s feelings about the speaker. It can let a student know that you are on their side and consist of the following types: • Agreement: <i>“Yeah, that class was tough for me too.”</i> • Offers to Help: <i>“I am here for you if you want to talk about it.”</i> • Praise: <i>“You are such a hard worker.”</i> • Reassurance: <i>“I know you’ll do a great job.”</i> • Diversion: <i>“That reminds me of a time we...”</i>
6. Analyzing: Occurs when the listener offers an interpretation of the speaker’s message (“I think what’s really bothering you is...”). Providing interpretations are often effective in helping a student see things from other perspectives. It can also clarify a confusing problem, providing an objective understanding of the situation, which can lead to a solution. However, analysis can create more problems than it solves, so to make sure that your feedback is helpful there are a few guidelines: • <i>Offer your interpretation in a tentative way rather than as absolute fact.</i> • <i>Your analysis ought to have reasonable chance of being correct.</i> • <i>Make sure that the other person will be receptive to your analysis.</i> • <i>Be sure that your motive for offering an analysis is truly to help them.</i>
7. Evaluating: A response in which the listener appraises the speaker’s thoughts or behaviors. The evaluation may be favorable (“You are doing an awesome job”) or unfavorable (“An attitude like that won’t get you anywhere”). When communicating with students it is important to be cautious of unfavorable evaluations as they may arouse defensiveness and threaten the self-concept of the student.

8. **Advising:** Responding by offering guidance or providing suggestions for dealing with the speaker's problem. Advice may be helpful or harmful. Although advice may be just what a student needs in certain cases, there are several reasons why it may not be helpful in other situations. First, you may not be offering them the best suggestion. Second, the position of "advice recipient" is a potentially unwelcome identity because it implies that the advice giver may be superior and that somehow the receiver is at fault. Lastly, people often don't want advice and instead may simply need to talk out their thoughts and feelings. When providing advice consider the following when trying to help students:

Is the advice needed? If a person has already taken a course of action, giving advice after the fact is rarely appreciated.

Is the advice wanted? People generally do not value unsolicited advice.

Is the advice given in the right sequence? Advice is more likely to be received after the listener first offers empathizing, paraphrasing, questioning, and supporting responses.

Is the advice coming from an expert? If you want to offer advice about anything, it's important to have experience and success in those matters.

Task

a. What would be an appropriate active listening response for each of these situations? If you believe the answer could occur in steps then clarify.

- i. A young nephew tells you that he can't talk with his parents. No matter how hard he tries, they just don't listen. "I tried to tell them that I can't play football and I don't want to play it," he confides. "But they ignore me and tell me that all I need is practice."
- ii. Your father has been having a difficult time at work. He was recently passed up for a promotion and received one of the lowest merit raises given in the company. "I am not sure what I did wrong," he tells you. "I do my work, mind my own business; don't take my sick days like everyone else. How could they give that promotion to Aslam who has only been with the company for two years? Maybe I should just quit."

b. What type(s) of listening you would use in each of the following situations? What type of listening would be obviously inappropriate in each situation?

- i. Your history instructor is giving a lecture on the contribution of the Ancient Greeks to modern civilization.
- ii. Your five-year-old sister says she wants to become a nurse.
- iii. A salesperson tells you of the benefits of a new computer. You think that he is making it up and only after selling his product.
- iv. A gossip columnist details the secret lives of TV celebrities.
- v. The television advertiser explains the benefits of a new electronic gadget.

c. Identify the types of listening from the statements given below.

1. Suppose your group suggests having a meeting on Saturday morning. Nicole seems upset. You want to understand how she feels about the proposed meeting. When she explains her concerns, you should focus your efforts on.
2. Two committee members make significantly different recommendations for the date and

format of the company's annual picnic. Which type of listening will help you decide which suggestion to support?

3. What type of listening is most appropriate when you want to acknowledge a member's effective language skills, use of humor, or skillful presentation of arguments?
4. What type of listening is most appropriate when you want to form appropriate opinions about the content of a message?
5. What type of listening is appropriate when you want to accurately understand the meaning of group members' spoken and non-verbal messages?

Case Study Practice Activity

1. **When Bob was involved in a serious automobile accident, Barry visited him in the hospital. What would be the best listening style for Barry to use when listening to Bob explain the details of the accident?**
 - Sympathetic Listening
 - Appreciative listening
 - Comprehensive Listening
 - Critical Listening
2. **Mary just loves listening to the song 'Chet and the Cow Pokes' on the radio. When the music comes on, she smiles, can sing along with every word, and sometimes breaks into dance. What is Mary's listening type?**
 - Appreciative listening
 - Critical listening
 - Empathetic listening
 - Comprehensive listening
3. **Carina has been talking to her friends about her most recent photography shoot with Steve for an hour. Her friends are looking away, fiddling with their phones, and are generally disinterested. What type of listening is taking place?**
 - Pseudo-listening
 - Comprehensive listening
 - Critical listening
 - Empathetic listening
4. **You ask one of your colleagues if they agree with a particular course of action regarding modification in the current Business Communication curriculum. He/she says yes by shifting uncomfortably to the other side, with a slight fall in voice intonation.**
 - Discriminative Listening
 - Empathetic Listening
 - Comprehensive Listening
 - Surface Level Listening

Common Barriers to Effective Listening

- **Physical and Environmental Barriers:** Poor acoustics/ sound quality, noisy surroundings, screeching sound of chairs, shouting and screaming of individuals.
- **Cultural Barriers:** Some cultures place more importance on listening than other cultures. In general, collectivistic cultures tend to value listening more than individualistic cultures that are more speakers oriented. The value placed on verbal and nonverbal meaning also varies by culture and influences how we communicate and listen. Interrupting others while they are talking, using slangs in speech without knowing the cultural values of the interlocutors create communication problems. Using over-polite expressions/ not using any polite expressions at all are some of the cultural barriers to listening.
- **Emotional and Psychological Barriers:** the ideas that run against our opinions and thoughts we tend to **tune out** the speaker and thus fail to hear, we put up a psychological barrier and block the speaker. This could be due to the emotions outburst.
- **Physiological Barriers.** ... Hearing disability, physical ailments(headache, dizziness, body pains that hinder listening ability)
- **Language Barriers:** Unfamiliar words, not knowing multiple meanings of a vocabulary item, unfamiliar accent, correct/ poor pronunciation, unable to understand the underlying meanings of expressions.
- **Making Assumptions:** Forming opinions based on your own past/ current experiences, putting your own judgments without knowing the ground reality, assuming different scenarios without understanding the speaker's intention to speak leads to disrupted listening.
- **Too Much Information:** so many different concepts are intertwined with one another, no clarity in ideas provided by the speaker; hence the listener is unable to comprehend.
- **Information Under load:** too little information is provided; ideas are devoid of any background knowledge/ context. Lacking clarity, vagueness in speech and thoughts.
- **Tone of Voice:** Not everyone will react the same way to different tones of voice, and two people might hear the same vocal tone in very different ways. For example, one listener might find that an energetic speaker is engaging/ influencing, while another might react emotionally to what they feel is a loud, impolite way to speak and characterizing as an angry tone.

Tips for active listening/ Effective Listening

1. Face the speaker and have eye contact. ...
2. "Listen" to non-verbal cues too. ...
3. Don't interrupt. ...
4. Listen without judging, or jumping to conclusions. ...
5. Don't start planning what to say next. The communication should appear natural maintaining a normal flow of expressions.
6. Show that you're listening. ...
7. Don't impose your opinions or solutions. ...
8. Stay focused and acknowledge the recipient/ speaker
9. Provide feedback if needed
10. Encouraging the communicator to speak

Listening Sub-skills

- 1. Listening for gist** – when we read or listen to get a general idea of the content of speech/text. We do not need to understand each and every word. For example, listening to a summary of the day's news on the television. Also, when we listen to a song, we want to enjoy it if we like its beats and tune even if we do not understand the lyrics or language.
- 2. Listening for Specific Information-** when we listen to discover a specific piece of information. We know in advance what we are hoping to find out. We can ignore other information that does not directly concern us. For example, listening to weather report to discover the weather in your city. At the airport, we listen for specific information when listening for information about our flight.
- 3. Listening in Detail-** when we pay attention to all the words and try to understand as much information as possible. For example, a member of a jury listening to a statement from a witness. Another example could be, when we are in a city we do not now and we have asked someone for directions to a hotel, we listen in detail so as not to miss out on any important piece of information.

Homework

Listen to the podcast audio and answer the questions provided below

<https://podcasts.google.com/feed/aHR0cHM6Ly9mZWVkcY5mZWVhYnVybmVyLmNvbS9pVHVuZXNQb2RjYXN0VFRIZWFsdGg/episode/MTAwMDYzMDQ3MDI2Mg?ep=14>

Activity

1. What did the speaker say after telling her name? What sort of emotional response she is talking about after getting an E-mail?
2. What is she talking about? (Name that specific ailment)
3. Clinical kind is the _____ kind that has increased tremendously.
4. Two powerful sign based tools for turning down ----- (complete the sentence).
5. Tool number 1 (as identified by the speaker) is -----
6. Inhale and exhale deeply on how many counts?
7. Tool number 2 is -----
8. Tool number 2 works effectively for -----
9. What brain chemicals are mentioned by the speaker?
10. These chemicals are called as ----- chemicals.
11. What techniques the speaker suggested when the heart starts pounding?
12. 10 minutes ----- has a mood boosting effect.
13. What sort of assessment the speaker conducted?
14. What two important things the speaker notified when the stress is under controlled? What will you be able to do? Use your own words to describe the question.

15. After getting warning signals, how one can overcome anxiety regarding work projects?
What examples of getting support from others the speaker has provided?
16. By the end of the audio, what sort of superpower the speaker is talking about?
17. What does 'empathy' mean?
18. What are the strategies to keep nerves in check?